

getting greater features in your car system. In terms of the interface, the Android Auto interface is slightly sluggish in comparison to Apple CarPlay. However, it is more graphical, although the graphics are all low res. Touch response is a tad slower than Apple CarPlay, too.

While Apple CarPlay does feel comparatively smoother than Android Auto, it is the latter that offers a complete in-car infotainment setup, with messaging, calling, voice interactions, navigation and music. Adding to that is the much larger third party app support and India's dominant Android smartphone user base, and Android Auto is certainly the overwhelming winner in this comparison.

To read more about how each fares, head to <http://dgit.in/CrPlyAndA>

The future

With Apple putting increasing focus on India, CarPlay is bound to get more third party applications, and hopefully, a robust navigation interface as well. However, the future of the automobile industry presently stands at a juncture where in-car infotainment systems will soon be about much more than music and direction guidance.

With the advent of autonomous and assisted driving experiments, in-car infotainment systems are looking forward to becoming self-sustained ecosystems that do not require a smartphone to operate. Instead, the idea for future in-car infotainment systems is to have always-on connectivity, integrated GPS modules to get live traffic updates (natively, without Google Maps), and essentially work as well as a smartphone in itself.

At the present moment, it is unclear what strategy Apple will adopt with CarPlay, when the time comes. Google and the Open Automotive Alliance have already presented concepts of Android working directly as the in-car operating system and even control aspects of the drive, and The Linux Foundation aims to establish just the same. These platforms also seem much more attractive than CarPlay, but what they do not have, and may never get, is compatibility with iOS devices.

To take an educated guess, Apple would also look to make in-car systems that run fully on iOS, in effect melding drive dynamics with infotainment in future autonomous and assisted vehicles. That, as of now, seems to be CarPlay's natural evolutionary path, although such times are still far into the future. **d**